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Emotional Intelligence

Read your emotions, steer your actions, and stay on track when it gets hard

COMPLETE GUIDE 4 OF 5

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> **Disclaimer.** This educational resource presents behavioral and emotional-skills strategies for personal development. It does not constitute medical, psychological, psychiatric or therapeutic advice. The author is a nutrition coach, not a licensed healthcare provider. If you have a mental health condition, an eating disorder, a substance dependence, ADHD or any other clinical concern, consult a qualified professional before making changes. If you are in crisis, contact your local emergency number or a crisis line. Individual results vary.

BEFORE YOU READ

Start here

Most plans do not fail on the day you are motivated. They fail on the day you are stressed, rejected, bored, ashamed or exhausted. On that day the plan is the same, but your emotions are louder than it is. This guide is about that day.

Emotional intelligence (EI) is a popular and sometimes oversold idea. I use it here in a practical way: noticing what you feel, understanding what it is telling you, choosing what to do with it, and reading the people around you well enough to keep your relationships working. I will tell you which tools have solid evidence, which have modest evidence, and which are simply good coaching practice. Where I could not verify a popular claim, I left it out.

How to use this guide

- **Read Chapters 1 to 4 first.** They give you the basic loop and the toolbox.
- **Then jump to what hurts.** Cravings and emotional eating: Chapter 5. ADHD: Chapter 6. Relationships: Chapters 7 and 8.
- **Practice one tool for seven days** before adding another. Chapter 10 shows how.
- **This is not therapy.** Chapter 12 explains when to bring in a professional, and it is a sign of strength, not failure.

CHAPTER 1

What emotional intelligence is, and is not

A working definition

The most cited scientific model, from Mayer, Salovey and Caruso, treats EI as a set of **abilities**: perceiving emotions in yourself and others, using emotions to support thinking, understanding how emotions work and change, and managing emotions in yourself and in relationships.[1] In plain language, those four abilities are:

Ability	In plain language	Example
Perceive	Notice what you and others feel	"My chest is tight. I am anxious."

Use	Let the emotion inform your thinking	"I feel uneasy about this deal. What is it pointing at?"
Understand	Know where it came from and where it tends to go	"When I feel criticized, I withdraw for two days."
Manage	Choose your response, not just react	"I will answer tomorrow, after I sleep."

What the research does and does not show

You may have read that EI matters more than IQ, or that it accounts for most of success. That claim is not supported. Meta-analyses find that EI measures relate **modestly** to job performance, and researchers disagree about how much they add beyond personality and general intelligence. One large meta-analysis concluded that much of the apparent benefit of some self-report EI measures overlaps with personality traits, and that the link to job performance depends on how much emotional work the job requires.[2] Another found that EI still explained some additional variance in performance beyond personality and intelligence.[3]

The honest summary

EI is a useful skill set, not a superpower. The reason to build it is practical: people who can name and handle their emotions tend to have an easier time with relationships and with sticking to hard plans. The size of the benefit is moderate, and it will not replace sleep, training, good food or professional help.

What EI is not

- **It is not being nice.** You can be very emotionally skilled and still say a hard thing clearly.
- **It is not suppressing feelings.** Pushing emotions down is one of the strategies with weaker results (Chapter 4).
- **It is not a personality type.** Skills improve with practice. Your starting point matters less than your reps.
- **It is not a test score.** Online quizzes are fun but do not tell you what to practice. Chapter 10 gives you better data: your own log.

CHAPTER 2

The loop: trigger, feeling, urge, action

Almost every emotional moment follows the same sequence. Once you see it, you can interrupt it.

1. **Trigger.** Something happens. A text, a comment, a scale number, a quiet evening.
2. **Interpretation.** You tell yourself what it means. "They think I am a failure."
3. **Feeling.** Your body and mind respond. Heat, tightness, sinking, restlessness.
4. **Urge.** You feel pulled toward an action. Eat, drink, scroll, snap, quit, hide.
5. **Action.** You do, or do not do, what the urge says.

The gap you are trying to build is between **urge and action.** You cannot always stop the trigger or the feeling. You can learn to widen the gap, even by ten seconds, so that you choose rather than react.

Naming the feeling helps

Putting a feeling into words is called **affect labeling.** In a brain imaging study, naming the emotion in a face reduced amygdala activity (a region involved in threat responses) and increased activity in a prefrontal region linked to regulation, compared with simply matching the faces.[4] Later reviews describe labeling as a form of implicit emotion regulation, with effects that are real but modest and that vary by person and situation.[5] It is not a cure. It is a cheap first move that costs nothing and can be done in a few seconds.

Be specific: the more precise the word, the better

"I feel bad" gives you one option. "I feel embarrassed" and "I feel lonely" point at different needs. Researchers call this skill **emotion differentiation.** People who describe their emotions with more precision tend to manage them with fewer harmful behaviors such as heavy drinking when upset, though most of this evidence is correlational.[6] Use the table below as a starting vocabulary.

If you say...	Try asking if it is...
"Stressed"	Overwhelmed, pressured, rushed, afraid of failing, afraid of letting someone down
"Angry"	Disrespected, blocked, treated unfairly, hurt (anger often covers hurt)

"Sad"	Disappointed, lonely, grieving, discouraged, tired
"Anxious"	Uncertain, worried about a specific outcome, on edge, unprepared
"Bored"	Under-stimulated, avoiding something, restless, in need of a break
"Guilty" or "ashamed"	Guilty: "I did something bad." Shame: "I am bad." Treat these differently.

The 10-second check-in

Three questions, any time: **What am I feeling (one precise word)? Where do I feel it in my body? What do I feel like doing?** If you can answer those, you have already opened the gap.

CHAPTER 3

Self-awareness: reading your own signals

Your body talks first

Emotions show up in the body before you have a word for them. Common signals include a tight jaw, a knot in the stomach, shallow breathing, heat in the face, restless legs, a sudden urge to check your phone. Learning your own early warning signs gives you more time to respond. Write down yours; they are personal and they repeat.

Body signal	What it often means for ME (fill in)
Tight chest or shallow breath	
Stomach knot or nausea	
Heat, flushed face, clenched jaw	
Heavy limbs, wanting to lie down	
Restless, cannot sit still	

Know your triggers and your patterns

Most people have a short list of triggers that cause most of their trouble. Common ones are: feeling criticized, feeling out of control, feeling lonely, feeling ignored, being tired or hungry, and comparing yourself to others. Your list is the one that counts. For two weeks, write down each time you were pulled off course and note the situation, the feeling and what you did. After two weeks you will see patterns that you could not see before.

Expressive writing: useful, but modest

Writing about difficult experiences for 15 to 20 minutes over several days is a well-studied exercise. A meta-analysis of 146 randomized studies found that it helps on average, but the effect is **small** (r = 0.075).[7] It works better for some people and in some conditions than others. Treat it as one inexpensive option, not a treatment, and stop if it makes you feel worse.

Try this: a three-line daily log (2 minutes)

1) **Highest emotion today** (one word). 2) **What triggered it.** 3) **What I did, and what I might try next time.** No essays. The point is the pattern over weeks, not any single entry.

CHAPTER 4

Self-management: the toolbox, ranked by evidence

Psychologist James Gross describes emotion regulation as a family of strategies that act at different points in the emotional loop: choosing situations, changing situations, shifting attention, reframing the meaning, and changing the response.[8] They are not equally effective. Here is what the research supports, in plain terms.

Reframing and distraction work; pure suppression is weaker

A meta-analysis of 306 experimental comparisons found that **cognitive reappraisal** (reinterpreting the situation) had a small to moderate effect on emotional outcomes (d = 0.36). **Distraction** was similar (d = 0.27). **Expressive suppression** (hiding the outward signs of an emotion) had a small effect (d = 0.32) on outward expression, but did not reduce how much

people actually felt.[9] In a related set of studies, people who habitually reappraised reported better well-being and relationships, while people who habitually suppressed reported more negative outcomes.[10]

Tool	What it is	Evidence strength	Best used when
Reappraisal	Find another honest reading of the situation	Small to moderate effect	Before or early in a feeling, when you have some thinking room
Distraction	Move attention elsewhere on purpose	Small effect; short-term	Intense moments you cannot solve right now
Slow breathing	Long exhale, around 6 breaths per minute	Small effect on calm and arousal	Anytime, especially before a hard talk
Self-distancing	Talk to yourself in the third person or from a future viewpoint	Moderate in lab studies	Rumination, stress before a challenge
Mindfulness practice	Regular practice of noticing without reacting	Small to moderate for anxiety and low mood	Daily, as a base skill
Suppression	Push the feeling down and hide it	Does not reduce the feeling	Short-term professional moments only

Reappraisal: change the story, not the facts

Reappraisal does not mean pretending. It means asking what else could be true. Not "it is fine" but "what is another honest way to read this?"

Automatic thought	Reappraised thought
"I ate badly, the week is ruined."	"One meal is one meal. My average is what counts. Next meal is the next vote."
"They did not reply, they are annoyed with me."	"They may be busy. I can ask, or wait until tomorrow."
"I missed my workout. I always quit."	"I missed one. The plan assumes some misses. What is the 10-minute version?"
"I have no willpower."	"I have a hard situation and not enough support in it. What can I change in the setup?"

Slow breathing: a small, fast tool

A systematic review of slow breathing techniques reported links with greater relaxation, comfort and alertness and reductions in anxiety, anger and arousal, mostly in small studies.[11] The effect is modest, and not a substitute for treatment, but it is free and quick. Try this: **inhale through the nose for 4 seconds, exhale slowly through the mouth for 6 to 8 seconds, for 2 to 5 minutes.** If it makes you dizzy, slow down or stop.

Self-distancing: talk to yourself like a coach

In a set of experiments, people who reflected on a stressful event using their own name or "you" instead of "I" showed less emotional reactivity and rated themselves as less anxious about an upcoming speech.[12] This is the "What would I tell a friend?" move, with a little more structure. Try: "Adriano, you are nervous. What do you need right now?" It sounds silly and works for many people.

Mindfulness: slow but useful

A meta-analysis of 47 trials found that mindfulness meditation programs produced **small to moderate** improvements in anxiety and depression, with low evidence for effects on stress and quality of life, and none shown for substance use or weight.[13] It is not magic. It is a skill that pays off with regular practice, five to ten minutes per day.

Pick two tools, not ten

Choose one tool for the moment of the feeling (breathing, or reappraisal) and one for the daily base (mindfulness, or the three-line log). Practice them for a week before you add anything.

CHAPTER 5

Urges, cravings and emotional eating

Emotion drives a lot of eating and drinking

The link between negative emotions and eating is real, though it is not the same for everyone. A review of studies found that **emotional eating** (eating in response to negative emotions) is associated with higher intake of energy-dense foods and with higher body weight, but the

strength of the link varies, and some people eat less when stressed.[14] In the alcohol field, a study of people in treatment found that **difficulty tolerating negative emotions** predicted alcohol use during and after treatment.[15] The same skill gap can show up in different behaviors.

An urge is not an order

An urge is a wave. It rises, peaks, and usually falls within minutes if you do not feed it. This idea is the basis of **urge surfing,** a skill taught in mindfulness-based relapse prevention. In a randomized trial of 286 adults after treatment for substance use disorders, those who got mindfulness-based relapse prevention had fewer days of substance use and heavy drinking at 12 months than those who got usual aftercare.[16] It does not work for everyone, and it works best alongside other support, but it shows that you can learn to ride out an urge.

Urge surfing: the five steps

1. **Stop and name it.** "This is an urge to eat/drink/scroll." Not "I need."
2. **Locate it in your body.** Throat, stomach, hands. Describe it like a scientist.
3. **Breathe slowly** while you watch it, 2 to 5 minutes.
4. **Notice it change.** Urges grow, peak and fade. Rate it 0 to 10 every minute.
5. **Choose.** After the wave, decide what to do. You are allowed to still choose the food, but now you choose it.

Emotional eating: three questions before you eat

Question	Why it helps
"Am I physically hungry?"	When did I last eat? Is my stomach asking, or my mind?
"What am I feeling right now?"	Uses affect labeling. Often the answer is tired, lonely, bored or stressed.
"What do I actually need?"	Rest, a call, a walk, a shower, a snack. Sometimes the answer is food. That is fine.

If the answer is "I am hungry," eat. A reliable plan with enough food (Guide 2) reduces the number of urges that are really hunger. If the answer is "I am stressed" or "I am lonely," the food will not fix that, and a small 10-minute alternative might (walk, shower, text a friend, tea, 5 minutes of breathing).

The pause rule

Before acting on a strong urge, wait **10 minutes** and do something else (walk, water, breathing). This is my coaching rule, not a clinical threshold. Many people find that after the wait, the urge is weaker or gone. If it is still there, you can decide with a clearer head.

Alcohol and recovery

I have been sober for four years, so this topic is personal to me, but I am not a treating clinician. If you drink heavily, do not stop suddenly without medical advice, because alcohol withdrawal can be dangerous. If you want to cut back or stop, talk to a doctor, and consider structured support such as therapy or a mutual-help group. The skills in this guide (naming feelings, urge surfing, planning for triggers) are tools to use alongside that support, not a replacement for it.

CHAPTER 6

ADHD and emotions

What we know

Emotional difficulties are common in adults with ADHD, even though they are not part of the formal diagnostic criteria. A review of the research concluded that emotion dysregulation (quickly arising, intense and hard-to-control emotional reactions) is common in ADHD and cannot be fully explained by other conditions that occur with ADHD.[17] A brain imaging study of adults with ADHD who were not on medication found lower dopamine transporter and receptor markers in reward-related brain regions, which correlated with inattention scores.[18] This is consistent with the everyday experience of needing more stimulation and getting less reward from routine tasks, but a single imaging study does not tell the whole story, and ADHD is not just "low dopamine."

About "rejection sensitivity"

You may have seen the term **rejection sensitive dysphoria** (RSD). It is popular online and many people with ADHD recognize it. It is **not a formal diagnosis,** and research on it in ADHD is limited. A related, better-studied idea is **rejection sensitivity,** the tendency to anxiously expect, readily perceive and strongly react to rejection.[19] If this sounds like you, the tools in this guide apply, and a therapist can help you work on it.

What helps (and what has evidence)

- **Treatment first.** Medication and psychotherapy are the best-supported treatments for adult ADHD. Cognitive behavioral therapy added to medication improved ADHD symptoms in a randomized trial of adults who were still symptomatic on medication.[20] Metacognitive therapy, a skills-based group approach, also showed benefits in a randomized trial.[21] Talk to a qualified clinician about options.
- **Shorten the loop.** ADHD emotions often rise fast. Use the 10-second check-in and slow breathing as automatic first moves.
- **Use outside structure.** Alarms, a visible plan, a friend you text when a feeling hits. Your internal brakes may be weaker, so build external ones.
- **Plan for the crash after a burst.** You may feel intense motivation, then a sudden drop. Decide your minimum plan ahead of time (the 10-minute version) so a low day does not turn into quitting.
- **Watch all-or-nothing language.** "Always," "never," "ruined." Replace with "this time."
- **Sleep and movement matter more.** Poor sleep makes every emotion louder (see Guide 5).

A note from my experience

I was diagnosed with ADHD as an adult. Understanding it did not remove the difficulty, but it changed the question from "what is wrong with me?" to "what does my brain need to do this well?" That is the question I would invite you to ask.

CHAPTER 7

Social awareness and relationships

Read the other person before you react

Social awareness is the skill of noticing what others feel and need. It does not mean mind reading. It means paying attention to tone, timing and context, and **asking** when you are unsure. Three habits cover most of it:

- **Listen to understand, not to reply.** Let the other person finish. Then repeat back what you heard: "So you felt ignored when I did not answer. Is that right?"
- **Check your assumption.** Before you decide what someone meant, ask: "I want to be sure I read that right. Did you mean...?"
- **Read the context.** Tired, stressed, hungry people communicate worse. So do you.

Respond to good news: the most underrated skill

Most people prepare for bad news and ignore good news. But research on close relationships suggests that **how a partner responds to your good news** matters for closeness and satisfaction. In four studies, sharing good events with someone who responded actively and enthusiastically boosted positive emotions and relationship well-being.[22]

Response style	What it sounds like	Effect
Active and constructive	"That is great! Tell me everything. How did you do it?"	Builds closeness
Passive and constructive	"Nice." (small smile, quiet)	Neutral to flat
Active and destructive	"Are you sure it will last? What about the downside?"	Hurts closeness
Passive and destructive	(Looks at phone) "Mm-hm. Anyway..."	Hurts closeness

Try this for a week: when someone tells you something good, stop, look at them, and ask two questions. It costs you a minute.

Asking for support

You do not have to carry it alone. If you are working on a hard goal, tell one or two people exactly how they can help. Specific asks work: "Can you text me at 8 PM on days I said I would train?" is better than "Please support me."

Situation	A script you can use
You need space	"I am overwhelmed right now. I need 20 minutes, and then I will come back and talk."
You need to be heard	"I do not need advice right now. I need you to listen. Can you do that?"
You need accountability	"Can you check in with me every Sunday evening about my plan? Two minutes is enough."
You want to say no	"Thanks for asking. I cannot do that. I can do X instead / I will pass this time."

CHAPTER 8

Conflict: say the hard thing without a fight

Conflict is not a failure. Unspoken conflict is what damages relationships. The goal is to say what you need while keeping the other person in the room. The steps below are common practice in communication training and coaching; the research on specific scripts is mixed, so treat them as a reliable starting point, not a formula.

1. **Cool down first.** If your heart is pounding, you will not be at your best. Ask for a break ("I want to talk about this properly. Can we do it in an hour?") and use slow breathing.
2. **Start soft.** Begin with the situation, not the accusation: "I felt hurt when the plan changed without telling me" rather than "You never think about me."
3. **Use the 4-part sentence.** "When [specific event], I felt [precise emotion], because [what it meant to me]. Could we [specific request]?"
4. **Listen to the answer.** Repeat back what you heard before you respond.
5. **Look for the shared problem.** What do you both want? Solve that.
6. **Repair.** If it goes badly, say so: "I got defensive. I want to try again." Repair after a rough moment matters more than avoiding every rough moment.

Common mistakes

Mistake	Try instead
Words like "always" and "never"	Name the specific event: "Last Tuesday..."
Mind reading ("You did that on purpose")	"I wonder if... Is that right?"
Bringing up everything at once	One issue per conversation
Texting through a big conflict	Call or meet. Tone gets lost in text
Winning	Aim to understand, then solve

CHAPTER 9

Emotional skills inside your transformation

Why this belongs in a nutrition and fitness plan

Every part of your plan has an emotional side. Training hard feels uncomfortable. Tracking food can feel shameful. Seeing a scale number can feel like a verdict. A missed day triggers "I always fail." The skills in this guide are what let you keep going through those moments.

Self-compassion: the evidence

Many people believe that being hard on themselves keeps them disciplined. The evidence leans the other way. A meta-analysis of 94 articles (about 29,500 participants) found that higher self-compassion was associated with better health behaviors (r = 0.26) and that multi-session interventions to raise self-compassion improved health behavior, while single-session inductions did not.[23] These are mostly associations, so they do not prove cause, but they do not support the idea that harshness is the secret.

After a slip, the harsh voice says…	The coach voice says…
"You blew it again."	"That happened. What was going on? What will you do differently next time?"
"You have no discipline."	"You have a plan that did not fit that day. Adjust the plan."
"Why bother?"	"One data point. Back to the next meal."

Movement as an emotional tool

Exercise is one of the better-supported tools for mood. A 2024 network meta-analysis of 218 randomized trials (about 14,000 participants) found moderate reductions in depression with walking or jogging, yoga and strength training, with larger effects at higher intensities. The authors also note that confidence in the evidence was low to very low for many comparisons.[24] So exercise is a real option, not a replacement for treatment when you have depression. If you are down, the 10-minute walk is almost always worth it.

Connect the guides

- **Guide 1 (TRANSFORM):** the Mindset and Recover steps use these skills directly.

- **Guide 2 (Nutrition):** regular meals and enough protein lower the number of hunger-driven urges.
- **Guide 3 (Environment):** change the space so fewer triggers reach you.
- **Guide 5 (Sleep):** a tired brain is an emotional brain. Fix sleep, and every tool here works better.

CHAPTER 10

Build your practice and measure progress

Start small: a 4-week plan

Week	Focus	Daily practice (5 to 10 minutes)
1	Name it	10-second check-in 3 times a day. Three-line log at night.
2	Body and triggers	Add: note your body signal for each strong feeling. Find your top 3 triggers.
3	One tool	Choose breathing OR reappraisal. Use it at the first sign of your top trigger.
4	One relationship skill	Active and constructive response to good news. One clean conflict sentence.

Measure what matters

Skip the personality quiz. Track simple things you can see change:

Measure	How	Good sign
Gap time	Time between a strong urge and your action	Longer
Recovery time	How long it takes to feel normal after a setback	Shorter
Precision	Number of different feelings you can name this week	More
Plan survival	Did you keep a minimum version on a hard day? (Y/N)	More yes

Repair	Did I go back and fix a bad interaction?	More yes

Review every Sunday for five minutes. Ask: What helped? What did not? What is one change for next week? Progress is rarely a straight line, and that is normal, especially with ADHD.

CHAPTER 11

Common pitfalls

Pitfall	What to do
"I should not feel this way."	Feelings are information, not verdicts. Name it, then choose your action.
Using tools to avoid feeling anything	Tools are for steering, not numbing. Some feelings, like grief, need time and people.
Trying everything at once	One tool, seven days. Then add.
Over-analyzing	Ten seconds to name, then act. Rumination is not insight.
Expecting calm all the time	The goal is a shorter, safer reaction, not no reaction.
Doing it alone	Tell one person. Consider a coach or therapist.
Giving up after one bad week	One bad week is data. Repair and restart.

CHAPTER 12

When to get professional help

These tools help with ordinary emotional ups and downs. They are not enough on their own when the problem is large. Please talk to a licensed professional if you notice any of the following:

- You feel persistently sad, empty, hopeless or numb for two weeks or more.
- Your anxiety, anger or panic is interfering with work, sleep, relationships or eating.
- You use food, alcohol, drugs, gambling or other behaviors to cope and cannot stop.
- You are binge eating, purging, restricting severely or feel out of control around food.

- You have had a major loss, trauma or abuse and it still overwhelms you.
- You think about harming yourself or ending your life.

If you are in danger or thinking of suicide

In the United States, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline). **In Brazil, call 188** (CVV, free and 24 hours). **Elsewhere, contact your local emergency number.** If you are in immediate danger, call emergency services right away. For help with substance use in the US, SAMHSA's helpline is **1-800-662-4357**, free and confidential. You do not have to be sure you are in crisis to call.

A coach can help you with habits, structure and accountability. A psychologist, psychiatrist or doctor can diagnose and treat. Both can matter, and seeking help is not weakness. It is what a good plan includes.

APPENDIX

Worksheets

1. Daily three-line log

Date	Highest emotion (one word)	Trigger	What I did / what I will try

2. Urge log

Time	Urge to...	Intensity 0 to 10	Tool used	After 10 minutes (0 to 10)

3. My trigger map

Trigger	My usual feeling	My usual urge	My new first move

4. Weekly review

Question	My answer
Longest gap between urge and action this week	
Something that helped	
Something that did not	
One person I will ask for support	
One change for next week	

About the author

Adriano Monteiro is a nutrition coach with Precision Nutrition certifications. He has lost 38 kg of fat, has competed in CrossFit for 8 years, has been sober for 4 years and has been in treatment for ADHD for 2 years. He writes and coaches for people who want lasting change without having to suffer in silence, and works with clients in English from Brazil.

Want help with the emotional side of your plan?

Book a free 20-minute call. We will look at where your plan breaks down on hard days and choose the first tool to practice. No pressure, no sales pitch, just a plan.

Book your free 20-minute call

https://calendly.com/adriano-nutrition/free-20-min-discovery-call

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